worked at the digs. The older of the two guides in front of the museum has worked with Bisht himself. The younger guide offers to show me several attractions in addition to the site: his Meghwal neighbourhood in the Dholavira village—one of its many neighbourhoods that are segregated by caste; the glow of the white Rann on the upcoming full moon night; unexcavated Harappan sites on Khadir Island where broken beads and pottery can still be found on the ground; a stone quarry used by the ancient Dholavirans; and a hill replete with wood and seashell fossils. Good thing I'm here for at least a week.

The Rise of the Harappans

The Harappan Civilization (aka the Indus Valley Civilization), alongside the Egyptian, the Mesopotamian and the Chinese, counts among the world's greatest Bronze Age civilizations. 'Civilization' here usually refers to urban life enabled by agricultural surpluses, specialized occupations, social stratification, writing or other symbolic communication, and monumental architecture. Lasting from 3300– 1300 BCE but thriving in its mature form between 2600 and 1900 BCE, the Harappan Civilization exceeded all other Bronze Age civilizations in both population (estimates range from one to five million) and geographic spread (nearly a third of modern India's size).[2] It 'was the most extensive urban culture of its time, about twice the size of its equivalent in Egypt or Mesopotamia'.[3]

The Harappan Civilization, discovered as recently as 1924, pushed back antiquity in the subcontinent by 3000 years. British archaeologist, Sir John Marshall, announced the discovery of Harappa and Mohenjo-Daro with great flourish in the *Illustrated London News*. In the preceding decades, many of its finds had been reported and studied, but the excavated artefacts had failed to fit existing theories; specialists couldn't decipher its symbols. Clearly this was something new. This groundwork had made Marshall's 'discovery' easier. Marshall himself had no clue about the age of the artefacts until, weeks after his announcement, it emerged that similar artefacts had also been found in ancient Mesopotamia. Funnily, an Indian archaeologist, Devadatta Ramakrishna Bhandarkar, had visited Mohenjo-Daro in 1911–12, but had 'thought the site was not old because the bricks